Westville Wall Project

Teens, paint, and public art that tells our neighborhoods' stories

STATUS	501(c)(3) public charity, Connecticut
FOUNDED	2018
BASED IN	Westville, New Haven (studio in a former storefront)
SERVES	Teens ages 14–19 from across New Haven
ANNUAL BUDGET	About $120,000
STAFF	Founder/lead artist (full-time), 1 part-time teaching artist
VOLUNTEERS	About 10 (artists, carpenters, a photographer)
REACH	About 45 teens per year; 2–3 murals completed

MISSION

The Westville Wall Project pays teens to design and paint public murals with professional artists, so young people see their ideas, and their neighborhoods, on the walls of their city.

OUR STORY

A muralist got permission to paint a blank wall at a corner store and invited neighborhood teens to help design it. So many showed up that she started a summer apprenticeship. The teens are paid a stipend, because, as one put it, 'art is real work.'

WHO WE SERVE

Teens referred by school art teachers and youth programs, plus walk-ins. Many say they don't feel heard at school. About half are in their first paid job.

PROGRAMS

Summer Mural Apprenticeship
Eight weeks, paid. Teens interview neighbors, design a mural together, and paint it with a lead artist. 20–25 teens each summer.

Open Studio Saturdays
Free drop-in drawing and painting during the school year. Builds portfolios and pipelines into the summer program.

Teen Lead Artists
Returning apprentices are hired to lead small projects and mentor first-year teens.

HOW WE'RE FUNDED

A state arts council grant (25%), commission fees from businesses and property owners who host murals (30%), a summer youth employment program that covers part of stipends (25%), and individual donors (20%).

WHAT WE TRACK TODAY

Teen attendance and hours (for stipends). Number of murals. Photos of every project. An end-of-summer group reflection that's recorded but never written up.

WHAT WE'RE WRESTLING WITH

Arts funders want 'creative youth development' outcomes; employment funders want job-readiness outcomes. The founder isn't sure how to speak to both without turning art into paperwork.

A MOMENT FROM OUR WORK

During a community unveiling, a shy 15-year-old explained to a crowd of 60 people why she painted her grandmother's garden into the corner of the mural. Afterward a neighbor asked her to design a sign for his barbershop. (Details changed to protect privacy.)